

BRITISH PARLIAMENTARY DEBATE AS DELIBERATIVE DEBATE

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“That doesn’t sound like debate, it sounds like an IE,” was a frequent assessment I heard from colleagues in response to my descriptions of British Parliamentary (BP) debate when I first started attending BP tournaments on a regular basis. To be sure, the four-team format where each debater gets one speech and where judges rank teams instead of assigning a win and a loss does not look like traditional policy debate formats in the United States. There is no negative block. There’s not a set of speeches designated as rebuttals. The affirmative team does not speak last. In fact, without collaborating, two teams have to argue the same side of a motion and produce arguments that are consistent with but distinct from the arguments offered by the other team. One team is done with their speeches 21 minutes into the 56 minutes of speaking time. British Parliamentary debate differs significantly from the two-team policy debate formats traditionally practiced in high school and intercollegiate debate in the United States.

However, categorizing BP as an individual event implies there is no clash of reasons, no exposure of positions to refutation and counter argument, and no exchange of ideas. In actual fact, British Parliamentary debate does the important work of argumentative exchange. Debaters bring ideas into direct clash with one another and must also work to subtly compare

claims on the same side of the topic. The evaluation that BP debate looks more like an Individual Event than a debate reflects an acceptance of and familiarity with a forensic model of debate that resembles the adversarial set up of a courtroom. Most debate formats in the United States are based on this forensic model: they have two sides, a winner and a loser, and single yes or no question to answer. BP stands outside the forensic model of debate due to its four teams, decision by ranking, and consistency between teams competing on the same side of the motion. Styles such as British Parliamentary are additive because “the traditional forensic model that dominates debate scholarship is not a productive lens with which to view all debate” (Kephart, 2005, p. 383). Many presidential and other political debates do not follow the forensic model of debate. I argue that the British Parliamentary format produces an authentic debate offering many benefits to students, judges, observers, and to discourse by generating a more deliberative exchange than traditional forensic debate formats. These benefits include greater public accessibility of debate, a format of debate appropriate for both openly democratic societies and those that are more restrictive, and serving as a site of enacting democratic citizenship. By acknowledging BP debate as deliberative, we can better understand its value as a debate and continue to work toward realizing the most promising outcomes of the format. In this essay, I will explore concepts of deliberative debate, explain the format and conventions of BP and why those contribute to more deliberative exchange, and finally discuss the implications of deliberative debate in an intercollegiate format.

Deliberative Debate

John M. Kephart III (2005) contrasted forensic and deliberative debate styles in his analysis of a 2004

presidential primary debate. Kephart identified the assumptions of forensic debate as having only two sides: for and against, as having the audience serve as observers with the judge making a single decision at the end of the debate, and the debaters serving the role of making arguments, not of being convinced by arguments (2005, p. 381). By contrast, Kephart posited that deliberative debate demonstrates that debate is not inherently oppositional. "We can view a debate exchange as having...the possibility of a constellation of affirmation and negation and not simply as a yes or no binary" (Kephart, 2005, p. 384). Clash, often discussed in terms of a direct response one gives to the argument of another, can be conceived, according to Kephart, as only one part of the debate. "It is also about engagement and transformation of the subject matter" (2005, p. 384). Because debate can be polysemic, it might be more than a "discreet event with one objective and an immediate decision" (p. 383). Deliberative debate, then, is one where we might have multiple affirmative perspectives and multiple negative perspectives, where we can conceive of clash as both direct refutation and the transformation of subject matter, and where we have arguments that serve more than one purpose and potentially more than one decision.

Scholars have explored the possibility of academic debate to serve deliberative functions (Elster, 1998; Harrigan, 2008; Keith, 2010; Mitchell, 2010; Stannard, 2006). These examinations have noted that debating can contribute to the production of positions, arguments, evidence, and persuasion to assist members of a democratic society in making decisions in the public sphere (Harrigan, 2008; Stannard, 2006). Jon Elster (1998) explained that the debating in Athenian democracy, where a few people would debate in front of

the audience of the assembly to persuade the assembly rather than one another “obviously falls short of what many proponents of deliberative democracy have in mind. Nevertheless, it may to some extent mimic the process of genuine deliberation...” (p. 2). This takes the audience to be the democratic decision makers who weigh what they heard in the debate to make a decision about the issue. Gordon Mitchell (2010) explored instances in which government agencies invited top intercollegiate debaters to research and debate policy questions they were considering. The debates revealed arguments and evidence relevant to their decisions, but that decision makers had not previously voiced because of institutional affiliations. William Keith (2010) noted many ways in which debate may be understood as a civic activity if framing debate as “argument in a democratic society” were privileged above the frame of “who’s the smartest” (p. 25), which is how Keith characterized the practice of traditional debate in the United States, based on the fight for the “win” in an adversarial win/loss situation. These accounts all look to possibilities in traditional formats of debate to serve deliberative functions. BP, by its nature, is already deliberative and thereby serves these functions not by mimicking, special invitation, or retooling, but by the conventions and practices of the format.

British Parliamentary Debate Format

The format is also referred to as WUDC or Worlds and is the format used at the Worlds Universities Debating Championship tournament held every December-January since 1981. The most recent WUDC was held in Thessaloniki, Greece, December 27, 2015 through January 4, 2016. The tournament has recently been held in Malaysia, India, Germany, the Philippines, and Botswana, and typically draws 300-400 teams from all over the world. The WUDC

Worlds Council made the decision in 1996 to adopt British Parliamentary debate as the official format for the tournament. Prior to that, the host institution chose the format for the tournament. For example, in 1995, American Parliamentary Debate as practiced by both APDA and NPDA in the United States was the format used at the WUDC hosted by Princeton University. This standardization led to programs in the United States adopting BP as a format for competition in the U.S. BP is now the fastest growing format of debate in the United States (Snider, 2010).

British Parliamentary debate features four teams of two persons, with two teams, referred to as the “government,” arguing in favor of the proposition and two teams, the “opposition,” arguing against it. The topic for the debate, called the proposition or motion, is announced fifteen minutes before the debate starts. The debaters may not consult with a coach, another team, or any electronic devices. They may bring prepared printed materials to the preparation time and the debate itself. Each of the eight debaters gives a seven-minute speech, occasionally yielding for a question or argument called a “point of information” from a member of a team on the opposite side of the motion. Most tournaments strive to place 2-3 judges in each debate round. These judging panels come to a consensus decision by discussion about the debate and conferring on the rankings. In this manner, debate teams are ranked 1-4. The judges then announce the rankings to the debaters and explain the reasons for their decision. BP as a format features several elements that foster democratic deliberation. The four outlined in this essay include: that teams on the same side must remain consistent with one another, yet compete to be ranked higher; that the teams are ranked rather than awarded a win or a loss; that judges decide ranks

by consensus; and the fact that that “role fulfillment” encourages all teams to make arguments relevant to the motion and relevant to the other arguments in the debate.

First, BP’s four-team format features two teams arguing in favor of the proposition and two teams arguing against the proposition. Both government teams and both opposition teams do not collaborate, but compete to be ranked higher in the debate. A team in the second half of the debate might rely on groundwork laid by the opening team on their side of the motion. For example, a second government team might use the first government team’s explanation of the status quo in setting up their own argument. An opening team might acknowledge the importance of a point of information raised by a member of a closing team on their side. Teams make use of common ground in ostensibly arguing for the same goal, but at the same time compete with one another to produce better arguments. Competition between teams on the same side is not direct, as teams argue as if they are in a coalition with the other team on their side of the topic to win the debate for their side. In reality, teams on the same side compete by attempting to produce the most relevant and persuasive arguments in the debate. In traditional forensic debate formats, competition is direct and adversarial. One might concede an argument strategically in forensic debating, but not have the opportunity to build coalitional arguments that bolster another team’s contribution or make use of that contribution to enhance one’s own argument. In British Parliamentary debate, debaters provide arguments about adopting the motion or not adopting the motion, and at the same time, make arguments about why their perspective is the most important in making a decision about the motion.

In the debate, teams must generate arguments that are distinct from the arguments advanced by the other team on their side. Debaters might do this by contrasting principled arguments with arguments about consequences. Or, for example, a team might offer arguments about the benefits a policy has to working families after an opening team has focused on the benefits a policy has to small businesses. Explicitly bringing different perspectives to the debate increases the deliberative nature of the discourse, because teams bring different stakeholders, different implications, and different types of appeals to bear on the central question posed by the motion. This corresponds with Kephart's evaluation of the 2004 presidential primary debate as having created multi-tiered deliberation (2005, p. 382). In the 2004 presidential primary debate all candidates argued they should beat the incumbent, but they argued about the importance of their own reasons for being the candidate to win. This primary debate was not directly adversarial, but was instead multi-tiered. Candidates agreed on certain issues while disagreeing on others. In BP debate, this creates the possibility of acknowledging the importance of another team's perspective, while at the same time, emphasizing the value that one's own perspective brings to the decision-making process.

Second, the debate does not result in a win or a loss for the side the debaters are defending. Rather, the four teams are ranked 1-4 by the judging panel. This decision does not adopt or reject the proposition for debate, but rather makes a judgment about the relative contributions of each team in the debate. Therefore, the central question posed by the motion does not get resolved, but teams who provide the best arguments addressing that question are rewarded with higher ranks. A team on the proposition side could

earn a 1, while the 2 could be awarded to a team from the opposition side. This ranking of teams evaluates each on the contribution they make to the debate, as opposed to making a decision about the correctness of motion being debated. The contribution of a team includes the persuasiveness of a team's arguments, their engagement with other teams through refutation and addressing points of information, and how well they addressed the central question of the debate. In this way, clash involves some direct refutation, engagement through attempting to resolve clash between two other teams, elaboration on points that have not been well developed, and keeping one's arguments relevant to the debate by making appropriate points of information. Rather than being occupied with defeating the other side, teams are focused on providing the best arguments in the round and showing the flaws with the arguments provided by teams on the other side of the motion. Because the team awarded a 2 is still considered to be in the winning half of the debate (and would advance to the next round if it were an elimination round), beating the other side becomes a secondary consideration to producing relevant and persuasive arguments. Relevant and persuasive arguments serve a more deliberative function than arguments based on dismissing another team, such as in topicality arguments in other debate formats, or arguments in a court of law to have a case dismissed. The emphasis on producing relevant and persuasive arguments rather than finding the right "trick" to win helps meet Keith's (2010) call for framing debate as argument in a democratic society instead of playing a game of who is the smartest.

Third, judging in BP debate happens via consensus of the judging panel. In most formats of debate in the United States, either a single judge renders a decision at

the end of the debate, or in the case of multiple judges, each judge makes an independent decision and the team with the majority of the votes wins the debate. In British Parliamentary debate, the debaters are excused following the conclusion of the speeches and the judges confer with one another to come to a consensus decision about the rankings of the debate. Rational choice models of democracy emphasize the ability to make a choice and vote for leaders in democracy, whereas deliberative democracy prizes the process of argument and discussion to get at a decision that is endorsed by all (Dryzek, 2000). In most forensic models of debate, judges are not allowed to confer about arguments, facts, or impressions, but must render an individual decision, mirroring the rational choice model of democracy. In evaluating BP debates, judges discuss the relative importance of arguments, how persuasive different positions were, and the extent to which a team has fulfilled their role. This helps adjudicators reach a decision endorsed by all judges. In this way, both the debating and the evaluation of the debate involve deliberative processes.

Beyond serving deliberative functions, consensus decision-making allows judges to check their impressions, biases, understandings, and misunderstandings with other judges on the panel. It also serves to normalize judging preferences and decrease judging idiosyncrasies. At many tournaments, such as the WUDC, the United States Universities Debating Championship, and some local tournaments, tournament organizers will hold a briefing, which explains any rules or norms of that particular tournament, the format of BP debate, and how they expect the judging to proceed. Most of the time, both judges and debaters are required to attend the briefing. In this way, judges learn or are reminded

of the community norms of judging BP debate and debaters hear what their judges are instructed to do. Typically, judges are advised to approach the debate as an ordinary intelligent voter to “abstract themselves from their personal positions when in debates” (World Universities Debating Championship, 2013a, p. 3). Even if a judge does not attend the briefing or decides to disregard the instructions, consensus judging provides a check on individual preferences, as judges must agree on the decision. Tournaments like WUDC and USUDC also make use of a judge feedback system, which allows debaters to rate the chair of the adjudication panel in terms of how well they explained their decision and if the decision made sense.¹ Chairs also rate the other judges on their panels and panelists also rate the chairs. This produces a tremendous amount of data for determining if judges are following the norms of BP judging and how effectively they are rendering and explaining decisions. The tournament uses this information to assign the highest rated judges to debates that are more crucial for determining who will advance to the elimination rounds. Larger tournaments also announce which judges will themselves judge the elimination rounds. Judges therefore have an incentive to conform to community norms in order to see better debates and to be publicly announced as an advancing judge.² This normalization of judging allows debaters to

1 Organizers typically take into account the rank the debaters received in the round so that the data is not simply an account of how happy or unhappy the debaters were about their ranking in the round.

2 Admittedly, there are problems with this model of assigning judges. Many feel as if this normalizes judging and debating too much, not allowing for much change over time in debating practices, as teams and judges both are rewarding one another for following a certain set of norms. Additionally, some feel this gives the tab room too much discretion over who judges which debate, as opposed to letting the computer assign judges randomly.

focus on making arguments that appeal to all involved, rather than tailor their arguments to the two judges who share similar preferences while ignoring the third judge who has a different set of preferences, which can often happen in other formats of debate. The individual preferences of judges are subordinated to the criteria of persuasive argument made within the boundaries of “role fulfillment” in the debate. This too, helps illustrate the way in which traditional forensic debate judging follows a rational choice model of democracy and BP follows a more deliberative model of democracy. In many formats of forensic debating (notably policy debate and NPDA Parliamentary debate), debaters must be aware of the preferences of their judges and attempt to adapt their arguments to those preferences. In British Parliamentary debate, the normalization of judging allows debaters to choose arguments that will appeal to all involved.

Fourth, the concept of role fulfillment in the debate helps debaters to construct a debate that is fair and deliberative. Role fulfillment is the extent to which each team and debater met the expectations for their position in the debate. The briefing document for the WUDC tournament in Berlin in 2013 stated, “Role fulfillment, in brief, is the name given to the particular duties given to each team on the table, by dint of their position, above and beyond the general duty to ‘make persuasive arguments’. These duties exist to ensure fairness” (World Universities Debating Championship, 2013b, p. 2). Johnson (2009), in his textbook *Winning Debates*, noted,

A common standard on the BP circuit is to evaluate each team’s merit by assessing whether that team’s speakers met the expectations of their respective roles. In a debate format that involves four teams competing independently

of each other—but requiring cooperation with at least one other team—it’s not surprising that adjudicators would have expectations regarding the contributions of each of the teams (and each speaker on those teams). Those expectations impart a certain structure and predictability to what may otherwise be a chaotic jangling of voices. (p. 238)

Debaters and judges are advised about the roles each team should play in the debate during briefings that are held at the beginning of some large tournaments. These roles include the responsibility of the first government team to define the motion and the debate, setting up a predictable and debatable exchange that all teams can participate in. Teams in the second half of the debate play the role of extending the debate by providing arguments that are loyal to the first half team on their side, but distinct from what has already been argued. The final speaker on each side has the role of summarizing the debate, but may not add new arguments in their speech. Each debater is advised that their role is to contribute arguments that are consistent with the arguments of their teammate and the arguments of the team on their side of the topic, and that each debater should accept at least one point of information during their speech and should strive to offer relevant points of information during the speeches of members on the opposite side of the topic.

These roles ensure that everyone has equal speaking time, that everyone understands the expectations to give arguments that are relevant to the topic as defined by the opening government team, and to participate in an engaged way by offering and accepting points of information. Role fulfillment discourages teams from interpreting the motion in an unusual or “squirrely” way, as most judges interpret the role of the opening government to define the motion in a way

that produces a debate about the central controversy suggested in the motion. Role fulfillment also suggests that teams on the opposition should debate the motion as interpreted by the opening government unless this is logically or morally impossible.³ Topicality arguments are nonexistent in this format. Role fulfillment ensures that all teams have the opportunity to prepare relevant arguments during the 15 minutes of preparation time. While the clash of the debate is shifting and polysemic with the development of positions and arguments throughout the debate, role fulfillment allows for a stable expectation of clash. When all debaters are encouraged to participate in addressing the central question proposed by the motion, a deliberative exchange, focused on producing the most persuasive and relevant arguments is more likely.

Implications of Competitive Deliberative Debate

The deliberative nature of British Parliamentary debate generates additional benefits for students, judges, observers, and society. Unlike most of CEDA/ NDT debate and, to a certain extent, NPDA debate, British Parliamentary debate operates in the public sphere of argument as opposed to a technical sphere of argument (Goodnight, 2012). There is very little jargon, speeches are typically organized topically with 2-3 main points, and the speed of the speeches is conversational, as opposed to using a fast delivery seen in many other U.S. formats. The form of reasoning is not specialized, but should appeal to the “ordinary intelligent voter” (World Universities Debating Championship, 2013b, p. 1). The consideration of the best arguments for making

3 This responds to Panetta and Atchison’s call for the stasis point of the debate to be centered on the resolution (2011). BP debate does exactly this. The opening teams must focus on the motion as the stasis point of the debate in order to fulfill their roles in the debate.

decisions and the focus on relevant and persuasive arguments in this deliberative format ensures the public orientation of BP debate. This public orientation makes British Parliamentary debate extremely accessible for first time debaters. Accessibility means that students without a high school debate background may immediately start debating. This encourages more voices, more perspectives, and a wider demographic involvement in debate than formats that require more training.

In addition to being accessible to first time debaters, the public orientation means that BP is a format of debate the public can identify with. Inviting the public to view debates increases the exposure to the deliberative exchanges that take place in the debates. In fact, at many World Universities Debating Championships, public officials have been invited to view the final debate. For example, both President Estrada of the Philippines and President S. R. Nathan of Singapore attended the final debate when the tournament was held in their respective countries. While regular tournament debating will likely not see a president of a country or even a president of a university attending rounds, we may see parents, friends, colleagues, or members of the community observing debates. Public exposure to the arguments, persuasion, decisions, and discussion of the debate means that rather than discourse remaining at tournaments, the deliberative discourse of the debates gains exposure beyond the immediate participants.

The same factors that make BP more deliberative than other formats of debate also make it appropriate for an international format of debate. The public rather than technical orientation makes the format accessible to debaters from around the world. Selegzi (2010) explained the ways in which BP debate is appropriate

for international debating, most notably, that ranking the teams instead of assigning a win and a loss can be a significant advantage in societies that are not as politically open and where judges may be reluctant to assign a win to a controversial position (p. 351).

The nature of BP debate as a deliberative exercise has important benefits to students, judges, and observers. In all forms of debating, students have an opportunity to test advocacy, evidence, and arguments in the simulated laboratory setting of the tournament. However, the deliberative and public nature of BP debate also ensures that, even in tournament debating, BP debate functions as more than a laboratory. Opinions, ideas, arguments, positions, and policies are formed in debate rounds. These arguments and ideas are shared, open for contestation, and receive feedback after third-party decision makers deliberate about them. Students, judges, and observers often have their opinions and positions changed as a result of hearing, evaluating, and contesting arguments. Consideration of the points debaters have developed, the points that other teams have made, the evaluation and feedback from judges, and discussions with teammates is the promise of deliberative democracy: decision making by discussion and argument. In a democracy, we make decisions in the voting booth; we raise our voices about an issue we care about; we enact democratic decision making when purchasing groceries and clothing and in deciding where we travel. Our choices have consequences. In British Parliamentary debate, students explore the potential consequences of these choices and learn to think about, understand, and appreciate the consequences of their choices in larger society.

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